

People have used bitcoin transactions to store data instead of transferring coins. For example, you could compute a hash of a document and store it in a blockchain. That can act as proof that the document being viewed has not been changed after that transaction. It could easily replace a notary. Dispute resolution could take minutes instead of, possibly, years.

Storing the hash of a document in a blockchain can also act as a proof in case of copyright claims.

While the bitcoin system is public and permission-less, companies are extending the system to add the need for permissions and create private blockchains. Banks are exploring the use of blockchains to make existing processes more efficient—for example, inter-bank transactions, trading of securities, money transfers, etc. Blockchain usage can enable inter-bank settlements without the need of a central bank.

One area in which consumers could benefit immensely is the transfer of money across countries. This is currently slow, and often involves hefty charges for both the sender and the recipient.

Settlements with credit cards take days. Credit card transactions add a significant cost to the merchants.

Settlements with blockchains can be done in minutes. Reports state that the Reserve Bank of India is looking into the possibility of using blockchains to reduce the importance and use of cash in the Indian economy.

Any item that has a value can potentially be traded and its ownership maintained using blockchains. You can get an idea of the range of applications being explored in an article called 'Let's Talk Payments' at <https://goo.gl/ZF78do>.

A number of countries are exploring the use of blockchains for land records and property transactions. This has immense social benefits as the existing processes are inefficient, incomplete and prone to fraud and corruption.

Time will tell whether blockchains live up to the current hype and expectations. There are open source alternatives to bitcoin blockchains that have additional capabilities, which you may explore, or you could even add to the efforts of groups building future blockchains. 

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OpenStack India will be co-located with Open Source India at Bengaluru, this October

OpenStack India 2016 will be co-located this year with Open Source India, which is Asia's largest gathering on open source. OpenStack India is a one-day conference for developers, users and administrators as well as a great place to get started with OpenStack cloud software.

OpenStack, which has thousands of developers all over the world working in tandem to develop the strongest, most robust and most secure product, is believed to be the future of cloud computing, where it is redefining Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS). Providing infrastructure means that OpenStack makes it easy for users to quickly add a new instance, upon which other cloud components can run. Typically, the infrastructure then runs a 'platform' upon which a developer can create software applications that are delivered to the end users.

As more and more companies begin to adopt OpenStack as a part of their cloud toolkit, the number of applications running on an OpenStack backend is

expanding. Because OpenStack is not owned by one single company, getting information about it can be a little tedious, which is precisely the reason for us pledging to ensure that our audience gets to know the latest in OpenStack. The idea is to bring you up-to-date information about OpenStack, to help provide answers to common questions from end users, developers and decision-makers seeking to deploy it in their organisations.

The most influential representatives of the open source community from India and abroad, as well as industry experts, will share the latest IT trends in the cloud architecture based on the OpenStack platform.

If you're looking for OpenStack related information/updates, products and services such as distributions, appliances, public clouds, consultants or training, this is where you should be!

Mark the date! It's October 21, 2016, at NIMHANS Convention Centre, Bengaluru.

